

Reading Companion

Essays to read *after* each film — 24 Aug 2026 – 4 Jul 2027

Links checked 19 August 2026

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Organized by unit, week, and film, matching [the syllabus](#). Optional-extension films are marked (*optional*).

The rule from the syllabus still holds: watch first, write your three or four sentences, *then* read. These are here so that when you want a second opinion you have one within a click, not so that you arrive at the film pre-interpreted.

About the sources. Criterion's Current essays are free and are usually the best single starting point for any film in their collection. Roger Ebert's *Great Movies* essays are free, short, and unpretentious. Senses of Cinema is free, longer, and more academic — its Great Directors entries are the fastest

way to place a film in a career. David Bordwell's *Observations on Film Art* is the formalist option and the one closest to the vocabulary in *Film Art*; where he's written on a film it's usually the most technically illuminating thing available. Scraps from the Loft reprints out-of-print criticism (Kael, Sarris, Kauffmann) that is otherwise hard to find legally online. Items marked (*paywalled*) need a subscription; a few need library access.

A note on links. Every URL here was loaded and checked against the essay it claims to be, as of August 2026. If one eventually 404s, searching the essay title plus the site name will usually find it — Criterion occasionally renumbers.

Unit 1 · The Grammar

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 1 · Aug 24–30

Citizen Kane (1941, Welles)

- **Citizen Kane: The Once and Future Kane** — Criterion. The film's critical fortunes, from Sarris vs. Kael onward.
- **Citizen Kane** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The standard appreciation of deep focus and "emotional chronology."
- **Welles at 101, KANE at 75 or thereabouts** — David Bordwell. What Welles actually invented versus what he inherited — the corrective to the origin myth.

Rear Window (1954, Hitchcock)

- **Rear Window** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Treats the film as a feature-length demonstration of montage and complicity.
- **Recuperation and Rear Window** — Senses of Cinema. The courtyard read through format and the architecture of looking.
- **Everything Jeff saw in "Rear Window"** — RogerEbert.com. A visual inventory of the apartment-block "screens."

North by Northwest (1959, Hitchcock) (*optional*)

- **North by Northwest: Long shots as close-ups** — Jim Emerson. Close formal analysis of Hitchcock's scaling and vectors — the crop-duster sequence taken apart.
- **North by Northwest archive review** — *Sight & Sound*. The contemporary verdict, from the archive.

Week 2 · Aug 31–Sep 6

Do the Right Thing (1989, Lee)

- **Do the Right Thing** — Criterion. The Cannes premiere and the film's refusal of easy sides.
- **Do the Right Thing: Walking in Stereo** — Criterion. Radio Raheem, sound, and the block as acoustic space.
- **Right hand, left hand: "Do the Right Thing" at 25** — Matt Zoller Seitz. Formal reappraisal at the 25-year mark.

Chungking Express (1994, Wong Kar-wai)

- **Chungking Express: Electric Youth** — Criterion. Frames the film as the *Masculin féminin* of the nineties.
- **Narrative Symmetry in Chungking Express** — Criterion. Short video-essay piece on the two-halves structure.
- **Wong Kar-wai** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. Career overview, strong on the step-printed editing vocabulary.

Killer of Sheep (1978, Burnett) (*optional*)

- **Killer of Sheep: Everyday Blues** — Criterion. Watts, Black American music, and the texture of dailiness.
- **Frontality and Time** — Criterion. Formal essay on Burnett's staging and duration.
- **Extraordinary ordinary people** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Ebert correcting his own 1977 review; plotlessness as statement.

Week 3 · Sep 7–13

Rashomon (1950, Kurosawa)

- **The Rashomon Effect** — Criterion. The four-testimony structure and its long afterlife.
- **Rashomon Rhapsody** — Michael Sragow, Criterion. Tests whether the film survives decades of imitation.
- **Rashomon** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Insists there's an explanation but no solution.

The 400 Blows (1959, Truffaut)

- **The 400 Blows: Close to Home** — Criterion. The film as record and exorcism of Truffaut's own childhood.
- **The 400 Blows** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Especially good on the final freeze-frame.
- **Truffaut's The 400 Blows, or the Sea, Antoine, the Sea...** — Senses of Cinema. Situates it among Truffaut's films about childhood.

A Man Escaped (1956, Bresson) (*optional*)

- **A Man Escaped: Quintessential Bresson** — Criterion. Bresson's method at its most distilled.
- **David Bordwell and Kristin Thompson Listen to A Man Escaped** — Bordwell & Thompson, Criterion. Visual essay on Bresson's nonsimultaneous sound.
- **A Man Escaped** — Gwendolyn Audrey Foster, Senses of Cinema. Economy, off-screen violence, free will.

Unit 2 · The Studio System

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 4 · Sep 14–20 — Screwball

It Happened One Night (1934, Capra)

- [It Happened One Night: Screwball Comedy?](#) — Molly Haskell & Phillip Lopate, Criterion. Two critics arguing over whether the genre existed yet.
- [It Happened One Night: All Aboard!](#) — Criterion. How the film became a how-to manual for imitators.
- [It Happened One Night](#) — Senses of Cinema. Good on the class politics under the romance.

His Girl Friday (1940, Hawks)

- [David Bordwell on the Magic of His Girl Friday](#) — Bordwell, Criterion. Framing, staging, and cutting choices you'd otherwise miss. **Start here.**
- [Words in Edgewise: Dialogue in His Girl Friday](#) — Criterion. How 191 script pages fit into 92 minutes.
- [His Girl Friday: The Perfect Remarriage](#) — Criterion. The most grown-up of the remarriage comedies.
- [Opening Shots: His Girl Friday](#) — Jim Emerson. Unpacks the newsroom tracking shot.

The Lady Eve (1941, Sturges) (*optional*)

- [The Lady Eve: Sweet Revenge](#) — Criterion. Sturges at the top of his run.
- [The Lady Eve](#) — James Harvey, Criterion. On the film's "energetic cruelty" and Stanwyck's command.
- [The Lady Eve](#) — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*.

Week 5 · Sep 21–27 — The Western

Red River (1948, Hawks)

- [Red River: The Longest Drive](#) — Criterion. The hinge of Hawks's career and his Cahiers rediscovery.
- [Hooked on Film: David Thomson on Howard Hawks's Red River](#) — David Thomson, Criterion. A critic's formative encounter.
- [Red River](#) — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On the older-man/younger-man core, and where the film wobbles.

The Searchers (1956, Ford)

- [The Searchers](#) — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Confronts head-on whether the film endorses or

indicts Ethan's racism.

- Pair with the unit's assigned reading — Manny Farber's "Underground Films" (1957) — which is largely an argument *against* the prestige-Ford register on display here.

Stagecoach (1939, Ford) (*optional*)

- **Stagecoach: Taking the Stage** — Criterion. How Ford bought the story himself and turned a B-picture into myth.

Week 6 · Sep 28–Oct 4 — Noir

Double Indemnity (1944, Wilder)

- **Double Indemnity** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On Seitz's photography and the "enigma that keeps it new."
- **Billy Wilder, Movie-Maker: Critical Essays on the Films** — Senses of Cinema. Book review whose centerpiece is on masking and ethics in this film.

The Third Man (1949, Reed)

- **The Third Man** — Michael Wilmington, Criterion. Moral corruption rendered as visual complexity.
- **Listening to The Third Man** — Criterion. Anton Karas's zither and what the score does.
- **The Third Man** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Vienna's rubble, canted angles, postwar knowledge.

Out of the Past (1947, Tourneur) (*optional*)

- **Far from Home: Three Noirs by Jacques Tourneur** — Criterion. Tourneur's noirs as stories of displacement.

Week 7 · Oct 5–11 — Hollywood on itself

Singin' in the Rain (1952, Donen & Kelly)

- **Singin' in the Rain** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Why the film's freshness hasn't dated.
- **La La Land: Singin' in the Sun** — Bordwell. Uses *Singin'* as the yardstick for what a movie musical actually does.

Sunset Boulevard (1950, Wilder)

- **Sunset Boulevard** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Especially strong on von Stroheim as the film's emotional anchor.
- **Sunset Blvd.** — Deep Focus Review. Extended reading of Hollywood's greatest self-satire.

The Bad and the Beautiful (1952, Minnelli) (*optional*)

- No strong free essay found. Senses of Cinema's Minnelli entry is the fallback.

Unit 3 · Silents, the Short Version

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 8 · Oct 12–18 — Keaton

Sherlock Jr. (1924, Keaton)

- **Sherlock Jr. (1924)** — Jeffrey Vance, Library of Congress (PDF). The best short scholarly account of the production and the gags.
- **Directors: Keaton** — Bordwell. His collected entries on Keaton's geometry and gag construction — the syllabus's assigned reading for this unit.
- **The Films of Buster Keaton** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Overview essay with *Sherlock Jr.* at its center.

The General (1926, Keaton)

- **The General** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Argues Keaton has aged better than Chaplin, and why.
- **The General (1926)** — BFI. Concise account of the flop-to-canon reversal.

City Lights (1931, Chaplin) (*optional*)

- **City Lights: The Immortal Tramp** — Criterion. Chaplin's fusion of burlesque and pathos.
- **Shooting City Lights** — Criterion. The famously agonized production, including the flower-girl meeting.
- **City Lights** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*.

Week 9 · Oct 19–25 — Expressionism

The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari (1920, Wiene)

- **A world slanted at sharp angles** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The first true horror film, and its break from photographic realism.
- **100 years of The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari: why we're still living in its shadows** — BFI. Centenary essay on the long influence — including on Week 6's noir.

Sunrise (1927, Murnau)

- **Sunrise** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On the camera finally learning to fly.
- **Sunrise: A Song of Two Humans** — Senses of Cinema. Murnau's first American film and its formal ambitions.

The Passion of Joan of Arc (1928, Dreyer)

- **The Bells of Saint Joan** — Criterion. Close-ups, oblique angles, and the trial as a spatial problem.
- **The Passion of Joan of Arc** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Centered on Falconetti's face.

Metropolis (1927, Lang) (*optional*)

- **Metropolis** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The film that fixed the image of the future city.
- **Lang, Fritz** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors.

Nosferatu (1922, Murnau) (*optional*)

- **Nosferatu** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The vampire film before the clichés set.
- **Nosferatu: Eine Symphonie des Grauens** — Senses of Cinema. Murnau embodying rather than explaining the myth.

Week 10 · Oct 26–Nov 1 — Montage and the avant-garde

Man with a Movie Camera (1929, Vertov)

- **A film about a film about itself** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Includes a striking average-shot-length comparison.
- **Man with a Movie Camera (1929)** — BFI. Short but sharp on Vertov's rejection of intertitles and actors.

Battleship Potemkin (1925, Eisenstein)

- **Directors: Eisenstein** — Bordwell. Collected entries on Eisenstein and montage; the clearest gloss on the theory the syllabus asks you to skim.
- **Battleship Potemkin** — Senses of Cinema. The Odessa Steps sequence and the myth-making cycle it belongs to.
- **1925: Battleship Potemkin** — Senses of Cinema. The film's actual (small) initial audience versus its legend.

Un Chien Andalou (1929, Buñuel & Dalí)

- **Un Chien Andalou** — Senses of Cinema. Buñuel's obsessions and his stated hostility to the "avant-garde."
- **Luis Buñuel: Eternal Surrealist** — Criterion. Career overview beginning with the shock films.

Meshes of the Afternoon (1943, Deren)

- **Deren, Maya** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. On the doubling, tripling, and cyclic structure.
- **Teaching Meshes of the Afternoon** — The Cine-Files. A dossier of scholars on how the film is read and taught — unusually good if you want to see the disagreements laid out.

The Crowd (1928, Vidor) (*optional*)

- **The Crowd** — Raymond Durnat & Scott Simmon, Senses of Cinema. Locates the film in an

international wave of screen populism.

- [The Man and The Crowd \(1928\): Photography, Film, and Fate](#) — The Public Domain Review. On the film's urban imagery and its literary ancestors.
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Unit 4 · Italy: Rubble to Ennui

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 11 · Nov 2–8

Rome, Open City (1945, Rossellini)

- [Rome Open City: A Star Is Born](#) — Criterion. "All roads lead to Rome Open City" — the film as origin point.
- [Martin Scorsese on Roberto Rossellini](#) — Criterion. A filmmaker's account of neorealism's shock.

Bicycle Thieves (1948, De Sica)

- [Bicycle Thieves: A Passionate Commitment to the Real](#) — Criterion. On finding the marvelous in the news item.
- [The Bicycle Thief / Bicycle Thieves](#) — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Tests whether the official masterpiece still breathes.
- [The Tribulations of the Working Class](#) — Senses of Cinema. De Sica's turn away from studio melodrama.

Umberto D. (1952, De Sica) (*optional*)

- [Umberto D.](#) — Criterion. De Sica on aiming for universality, plus reception history.
- [Seeing Clearly Through Tears: On the Smart Sentiment of Umberto D.](#) — Criterion. Defends the long undramatic passages against the charge of sentimentality.

Week 12 · Nov 9–15

L'Avventura (1960, Antonioni)

- [L'avventura: A Present Absence](#) — Criterion. The disappearance as the film's real subject. (*the syllabus's assigned reading*)
- [David Bordwell on the Restraint of L'avventura](#) — Bordwell, Criterion. How Antonioni withholds narrative information through composition.
- [L'Avventura](#) — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Ebert on coming around after twice resisting it.
- [L'avventura: the film that redefined the cinema](#) — *Sight & Sound*. On shifting the narrative burden onto the image.

Il Sorpasso (1962, Risi)

- **Il sorpasso: The Joys of Disillusionment** — Criterion. Risi's exasperated love for the country he's satirizing.
- **Il sorpasso: Italy, Dark and Light** — Criterion. Situates the film inside *commedia all'italiana*.
- **Alexander Payne on Il sorpasso** — Criterion. A director on what he stole for *Sideways*.

L'Eclisse (1962, Antonioni) (*optional*)

- **L'eclisse: A Vigilance of Desire** — Criterion. The film as culmination of the trilogy.
- **At the End of Love's Road with Michelangelo Antonioni** — Criterion. On the famous final montage.

Week 13 · Nov 16–22

8½ (1963, Fellini)

- **8½: When "He" Became "I"** — Criterion. Fellini turning the camera on himself. (*the syllabus's assigned reading*)
- **8 1/2** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The case for it as the best film about filmmaking.
- **"A Fantastic, Enchanted Ballet"** — Senses of Cinema. Fantasy, reality, and self-deprecation as method.

The Conformist (1970, Bertolucci)

- **Shadows of the Psyche: The Conformist** — *American Cinematographer*. Storaro's lighting design in detail — read this one before Unit 8.
- **Weary Shadow: Considering The Conformist** — Bright Lights Film Journal. Long critical essay on style and complicity.
- **The Knotty Legacy of Bernardo Bertolucci** — Criterion. Reckons with the director and this film's near-perfection.

La Dolce Vita (1960, Fellini) (*optional*)

- **La dolce vita: Tuxedos at Dawn** — Criterion.
- **La Dolce Vita** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The film Ebert measured his own life against, re-watching it each decade.
- **La dolce vita: unlocking the images in Fellini's visual feast** — BFI. An image-by-image guide.

Unit 5 · The French New Wave and What It Stole

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 14 · Nov 23–29

Bob le Flambeur (1956, Melville)

- **Bob le flambeur** — Criterion. Melville's "elegantly rigorous" heist picture and its cockeyed romanticism.
- **Melville, Jean-Pierre** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. Positions Bob as the proto-New Wave film made outside the industry.

Breathless (1960, Godard)

- **Breathless Then and Now** — Dudley Andrew, Criterion. The standard scholarly essay on the rupture and its afterlife.
- **Breathless** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Argues the revolution is pacing and detachment, not just jump cuts.
- **Class of 1960** — Bordwell. Places *À bout de souffle* among its 1960 contemporaries — the useful antidote to "it came from nowhere."

The Killing (1956, Kubrick) (*optional*)

- **The Killing: Kubrick's Clockwork** — Haden Guest, Criterion. The first mature statement of Kubrick's style.
- **The Killers Inside Me** — Chuck Stephens, Criterion. The film's noir lineage and its ensemble of faces.

Week 15 · Nov 30–Dec 6

Cléo from 5 to 7 (1962, Varda)

- **Cléo from 5 to 7** — Molly Haskell, Criterion. Varda's first fully achieved feature and its portrait of a woman's evolution.
- **Cléo from 5 to 7: Passionate Time** — Criterion. The real-time construction and cinéma-vérité charge.
- **Varda, Agnès** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. On the "grandmother of the New Wave."

Jules and Jim (1962, Truffaut)

- **On Jules and Jim** — Criterion. Truffaut's decade-long obsession with Roché's novel, and the elliptical style.
- **Truffaut, François** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. Full career overview with this film at its center.

Band of Outsiders (1964, Godard) (*optional*)

- **Band of Outsiders: Madison-sur-Seine** — Criterion. Reads the film as "a love story with a bullet in it."
- **When Anna Met Jean-Luc** — Criterion. On Karina and Godard's collaboration.

Week 16 · Dec 7–13

Contempt (1963, Godard)

- **Contempt: The Story of a Marriage** — Criterion. Marriage, Moravia, and CinemaScope.
- **Godard: The Power of Imperfection** — Bordwell. His obituary-essay on Godard's formal method; the best short account of what Godard was doing across the whole run.

Le Samourai (1967, Melville)

- **Le samourai: Death in White Gloves** — Criterion. Melville as lone operator and importer of American genre.
- **The Sound of Silence in Le samourai** — Criterion. On the film's dread-inducing use of silence.
- **Cinematic Cool: Jean-Pierre Melville's Le Samourai** — Senses of Cinema. Close annotation of style and the Delon persona.

Pierrot le Fou (1965, Godard) (*optional*)

- **Pierrot le fou: Self-Portrait in a Shattered Lens** — Criterion.
- **Godard in Fragments** — Criterion. Survey of the sixties run.

(Holiday break: Dec 14 – Jan 3.)

Unit 6 · Japan

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 17 · Jan 4–10 — Ozu

Late Spring (1949, Ozu)

- **Late Spring: Home with Ozu** — Criterion. The turning point in Ozu's development.
- **Ozu and the Poetics of Cinema** — David Bordwell (free full text, U. Michigan). The book-length study. Don't read it all — the chapters on the postwar films are the point, and this is the deepest Bordwell on the syllabus.
- **The Ozu Shot: Tokyo-ga and Late Spring** — Criterion. Camera height, and Wenders's tribute.

Tokyo Story (1953, Ozu)

- **Tokyo Story: Compassionate Detachment** — Criterion. Ozu beside Austen and Chekhov; the 180-degree cut and the low camera. (*the syllabus's assigned reading*)
- **Watch again! Look well! Look! (For Ozu)** — Bordwell.
- **Tokyo Story** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*.

Early Summer (1951, Ozu) (*optional*)

- **Early Summer** — Criterion. The nineteen-character ensemble and the strain of passing time.
- **A modest extravagance: Four looks at Ozu** — Bordwell. Four analytical passes at the method.
- **Is Ozu Slow?** — Senses of Cinema. Takes apart the cliché.

Week 18 · Jan 11–17 — Kurosawa, at length

Seven Samurai (1954, Kurosawa)

- **The Hours and Times: Kurosawa and the Art of Epic Storytelling** — Criterion. Why the film needs its three and a half hours.
- **A Time of Honor: Seven Samurai and Sixteenth-Century Japan** — Criterion. The historical setting and the bushido code.
- **The Seven Samurai** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Character-by-character reading of the seven.

Yojimbo (1961, Kurosawa) (*optional*)

- **Yojimbo: West Meets East** — Criterion. Kurosawa borrowing American genres, and Leone borrowing back.

Week 19 · Jan 18–24

Ugetsu (1953, Mizoguchi)

- **Mizoguchi: Secrets of the Exquisite Image** — Bordwell. Shot-by-shot on the staging and long takes. **The best formal piece in this unit.**
- **Ugetsu: From the Other Shore** — Criterion. Sources in Ueda's *Tales of Moonlight and Rain*.
- **Ugetsu** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The scroll shot and the film's elegant mystery.

Harakiri (1962, Kobayashi)

- **Harakiri: Kobayashi and History** — Criterion. Kobayashi's standing critique of authoritarian power.
- **Sword of the Beast: Rebel Samurai Cinema** — Criterion. Context for the anti-feudal samurai cycle.

Sansho the Bailiff (1954, Mizoguchi) (*optional*)

- **Sansho the Bailiff: The Lessons of Sansho** — Criterion. The Mori Ōgai source and the moral architecture.
- **Re-viewing Mizoguchi, Master Choreographer of the Long Take** — Senses of Cinema. Technical account of the long-take style.

Week 20 · Jan 25–31

High and Low (1963, Kurosawa)

- **High and Low: Between Heaven and Hell** — Criterion. Space, class, and composition across the two halves — exactly the split the syllabus flags.
- **Without Motive: The Last Scene in High and Low** — Criterion. Close reading of the prison confrontation.

Woman in the Dunes (1964, Teshigahara)

- **Woman in the Dunes: Shifting Sands** — Criterion. Teshigahara's ikebana and ceramics background as the visual key.
- **Woman in the Dunes** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Why the parable doesn't wear out.

Tokyo Drifter (1966, Suzuki) (*optional*)

- **Tokyo Drifter: Catch My Drift** — Criterion. Beauty and the void inside a studio potboiler.
 - **A Salute to Seijun Suzuki** — Criterion. Tributes on Suzuki's death.
-

Unit 7 · The Northern Interior

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 21 · Feb 1–7

Wild Strawberries (1957, Bergman)

- **Wild Strawberries: "Where Is the Friend I Seek?"** — Mark Le Fanu, Criterion. Sjöström, memory, and Bergman's mildest masterpiece.
- **Bergman, Ingmar** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. Notes the film's temporal layering.

The Seventh Seal (1957, Bergman)

- **The Seventh Seal: There Go the Clowns** — Criterion. Recovers the actual film from under its reputation.
- **The Seventh Seal** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On the directness that survives the parodies.

Winter Light (1963, Bergman) (*optional*)

- **Winter Light** — Criterion. Bergman's most concentrated inquiry into Lutheranism.
- **Bergman, Antonioni, and the Stubborn Stylists** — Bordwell. A skeptical formal assessment — worth reading precisely because it argues with the unit.

Week 22 · Feb 8–14

Persona (1966, Bergman)

- **The Persistence of Persona** — Criterion. The prologue, the metacinema, and the film's admission of artifice.
- **Persona** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. "We return to it over the years... and despair of finding" its buried truths.
- **10 Things I Learned: Persona** — Criterion. Production details; light reading after a heavy film.

Ordet (1955, Dreyer)

- **Ordet** — Chris Fujiwara, Criterion. The strangeness of the film, and the resurrection scene. (*the*

syllabus's assigned reading)

- **Sight & Sound Poll 2012: Ordet** — Criterion. Short case for its canonical standing.

Cries and Whispers (1972, Bergman) (*optional*)

- **Cries and Whispers** — Criterion. The body, dying, and Bergman's red "interior of the soul."

Week 23 · Feb 15–21

Stalker (1979, Tarkovsky)

- **Stalker: Meaning and Making** — Criterion. The Strugatskys' *Roadside Picnic* and Tarkovsky's transformation of it.
- **Geoff Dyer on the Miracle of Stalker** — Geoff Dyer, Criterion. Close attention to one haunting sequence; Dyer's book-length *Zona* is the extended version if it takes.
- **1979: Stalker** — Senses of Cinema. The film within Soviet film history.

Solaris (1972, Tarkovsky)

- **Solaris: Inner Space** — Phillip Lopate, Criterion. Solaris as a drama of grief and partial recovery.
- **Solaris** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Ebert resisting, then surrendering to, Tarkovsky.
- **Tarkovsky, Andrei** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. Cinematic time, poetry, and the fights with Soviet authorities — good background for *Sculpting in Time*.

Andrei Rublev (1966, Tarkovsky) (*optional*)

- **Andrei Rublev: An Icon Emerges** — Criterion. The film's suppression and its ideological trouble.
 - **The Passion According to Andrei** — Senses of Cinema. Faith, art, and the bell episode.
-

Unit 8 · New Hollywood

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 24 · Feb 22–28

Bonnie and Clyde (1967, Penn)

- **Bonnie and Clyde** — Pauline Kael, *The New Yorker* (1967). The famous long essay that rescued the film's reputation — and the piece that made Kael's career.
- **Bonnie and Clyde: Gangsters on the Road to Nowhere** — Richard Gilman. The skeptical contemporary counterweight to Kael. Read both.
- **Bonnie and Clyde** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. His 1998 reappraisal of a film he championed on opening day.

The Graduate (1967, Nichols)

- **The Graduate: Intimations of a Revolution** — Frank Rich, Criterion. Situates the film in the quieter mid-sixties, before 1968.
- **The Graduate** — Roger Ebert. His 30th-anniversary rethink, flipping sympathy from Benjamin to Mrs. Robinson.

The Wild Bunch (1969, Peckinpah) (*optional*)

- **The Wild Bunch** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On the restored 144-minute cut and how the quiet scenes change it.
- **The Last Man: An Epitaph for Sam Peckinpah** — Senses of Cinema. On Peckinpah's obsolescent men and their codes.

Week 25 · Mar 1–7

The Godfather (1972, Coppola)

- **The Godfather** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The Mafia seen from the inside.
- **"The Godfather" and the Decline of Marlon Brando** — Stanley Kauffmann. A dissenting contemporary reading, useful against the consensus.
- **The Godfather** — Vincent Canby, *NYT* (1972). A snapshot of first reception.

Chinatown (1974, Polanski)

- **Chinatown** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Reads Gittes against the Bogart archetype, plus the Owens Valley history.
- **Chinatown** — Tom Milne, *Sight and Sound*. Sharp on the film's relation to classic noir — i.e. to Unit 2.

The Godfather Part II (1974, Coppola) (*optional*)

- **"This is the business we've chosen"** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On the parallel-structure design and Michael's collapse.
- **Coppola, Francis Ford** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. Frames the whole seventies run.

Week 26 · Mar 8–14

Nashville (1975, Altman)

- **Nashville** — Pauline Kael, *The New Yorker* (1975). The legendary pre-release rave. (*the syllabus's assigned reading*)
- **Nashville: America Singing** — Molly Haskell, Criterion. On the film's contradictions.
- **Nashville** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Explicitly in dialogue with Kael; good on Altman's ensemble method.

Taxi Driver (1976, Scorsese)

- **Paul Schrader on 'Taxi Driver'** — Schrader with Richard Thompson. The best primary document on the script's origins.
- **Taxi Driver** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On the film's confinement to Travis's point of view.

McCabe & Mrs. Miller (1971, Altman) (*optional*)

- **McCabe & Mrs. Miller: Showdowns** — Nathaniel Rich, Criterion. Strong on overlapping sound and anti-western revisionism.
- **Stranger Songs: The Music of Leonard Cohen in McCabe & Mrs. Miller** — Robert Christgau, Criterion. How three early Cohen songs shape the film.
- **McCabe & Mrs. Miller** — Pauline Kael.

Week 27 · Mar 15–21

Days of Heaven (1978, Malick)

- **Days of Heaven: On Earth as It Is in Heaven** — Adrian Martin, Criterion. The best single essay: Linda Manz's voice-over and Malick's cellular editing.
- **Days of Heaven** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On Almendros's magic-hour photography and the film's elegiac distance.

Apocalypse Now (1979, Coppola)

- **Apocalypse Now** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Ebert at twenty years' distance.
- **Apocalypse Now** — Veronica Geng, *The New Yorker*. A witty, skeptical contemporary review.
- **Reflections on Coppola, Director's Cuts, and Apocalypse Now Redux** — Senses of Cinema. Useful if you're choosing between the 1979 cut and Redux.

The Conversation (1974, Coppola) (*optional*)

- **The Conversation** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Harry Caul destroyed by his own detachment.
- **Notes on The Conversation** — Senses of Cinema. Compact essay on sound, paranoia, and Walter Murch.

Unit 9 · Hong Kong and Taiwan

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Unit-wide: Bordwell's *Planet Hong Kong*, 2nd ed. is free as a [PDF](#) — the standard account of Hong Kong action aesthetics, and the syllabus's assigned reading for the unit.

Week 28 · Mar 22–28 — Wong Kar-wai

Days of Being Wild (1990, Wong)

- **World of Wong Kar Wai: Like the Most Beautiful Times** — John Powers, Criterion. Box-set essay that anchors Wong's style in this film.
- **Harbor Lights** — Nathan Kosub, Reverse Shot. Wong's 1960s Hong Kong as a landscape of missed time.
- **Years of being obscure** — Bordwell. Shot-by-shot comparison of the rare alternate cut against the international version.

In the Mood for Love (2000, Wong)

- **In the Mood for Love: Haunted Heart** — Steve Erickson, Criterion. (*the syllabus's assigned reading*)
- **In the mood for WKW** — Bordwell. On Wong's revise-as-you-go production, colour, and framing.
- **Like a Ritual in Transfigured Time** — Stephen Teo, Senses of Cinema. The standard early critical reading, by a leading HK cinema scholar.
- **Of Love and the City** — Kent Jones, *Film Comment*. Long-form appraisal on release.

Happy Together (1997, Wong) (*optional*)

- **The Tempest** — Matt Connolly, Reverse Shot. A queer romance that refuses consolation.
- **Cult Confusion** — Jonathan Rosenbaum, *Chicago Reader* (1998). A skeptical full-length review, with his later revision of the verdict appended.

Week 29 · Mar 29–Apr 4

Yi Yi (2000, Yang)

- **Yi Yi: Time and Space** — Kent Jones, Criterion. On the inseparability of character and environment.
- **Alone in a Crowd** — Jonathan Rosenbaum, *Chicago Reader* (2001). The strongest long review in his archive.
- **Good and good for you** — Bordwell. *Yi Yi* as the accessible gateway that finally won Yang a US audience.

Hard Boiled (1992, Woo)

- **PLANET HONG KONG: The dragon dances** — Bordwell. The core essay on HK action aesthetics — legibility, and the “pause/burst/pause” rhythm. **Start here.**
- **Hard Boiled** — Barbara Scharres, Criterion. Frames the film against pre-handover anxiety.
- **A glance at blows** — Bordwell. His manifesto for “carnal cinema” against Hollywood's impressionistic blur.

A City of Sadness (1989, Hou Hsiao-hsien) (*optional*)

- **A Cinema Beyond Us** — Kevin B. Lee, Reverse Shot. On Hou's historiography and the limits of the frame.
- **Hou Hsiao-hsien: A new video lecture!** — Bordwell. His full lecture on Hou's staging, plus the

free *Staging Memories* PDF.

- **Taiwan Stories: The New Cinema of the 1980s** — MUBI Notebook. Movement overview with this film as its pivot.

Week 30 · Apr 5–11

A Brighter Summer Day (1991, Yang)

- **A BRIGHTER SUMMER DAY: Yang and his gangs** — Bordwell. The definitive close analysis of staging, offscreen space, and network narrative. Worth the four hours you just spent.
 - **A Brighter Summer Day: Coming of Age in Taipei** — Godfrey Cheshire, Criterion. (*the syllabus's assigned reading*)
 - **From Elvis in Taipei** — Ben Ratliff, Criterion. On “Are You Lonesome Tonight?” as the film’s organizing motif.
 - **The Yin of Yang** — Andrew Chan, Reverse Shot.
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Unit 10 · Off the Usual Axis

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 31 · Apr 12–18 — Satyajit Ray

Pather Panchali (1955, Ray)

- **The Apu Trilogy: Every Common Sight** — Terrence Rafferty, Criterion. How Ray built a first film out of a child’s eye.
- **The Apu Trilogy: Behind the Universal** — Girish Shambu, Criterion. Argues Ray’s “universality” is grounded in specific Bengali texture.
- **Interview: Satyajit Ray** — James Blue, *Film Comment* (1968). Ray at length on directing non-actors — relevant given the amateur crew.

Charulata (1964, Ray)

- **Charulata: “Calm Without, Fire Within”** — Philip Kemp, Criterion. The Tagore source, the opera-glasses opening, and allusions Western viewers miss.
- **Charulata: The Intimacies of a Broken Nest** — Senses of Cinema. A dedicated close reading.
- **Ray, Satyajit** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors.

Aparajito (1956, Ray) (*optional*)

- **Il Cinema Ritrovato: revelations from India and Iran** — Kristin Thompson. On the restoration, including how much of the negative survived the fire.
- **The Apu Trilogy** — MUBI Notebook. Feature on the restored trilogy.

Week 32 · Apr 19–25 — Iran

Close-Up (1990, Kiarostami)

- **Close-up: Prison and Escape** — Godfrey Cheshire, Criterion. The definitive English-language essay: the Sabzian case, and exactly what was staged. (*the syllabus's assigned reading — and the one that will feed your epistemology opinions*)
- **Kiarostami, Abbas** — Mehrnaz Saeed-Vafa, Senses of Cinema, Great Directors.
- **The Shortest Way to the Truth: Kiarostami Remembered** — Criterion. Good on his method with nonactors.

Taste of Cherry (1997, Kiarostami)

- **Taste of Cherry: Stay Near the Tree** — A. S. Hamrah, Criterion. Best on the video coda and the refusal to explain Badii.
- **Taste of Cherry** — Roger Ebert. The notorious one-star pan. Read it against Hamrah, who effectively answers it.
- **With Borrowed Eyes: An Interview with Abbas Kiarostami** — *Film Comment*. Kiarostami on the ending and his method.

Where Is the Friend's House? (1987, Kiarostami) (*optional*)

- **The Koker Trilogy: Journeys of the Heart** — Godfrey Cheshire, Criterion. Its opening third closely reads this film, including the Sepehri poem and the zigzag hill.
- **Realism, Morality and Care in Where Is the Friend's House?** — Senses of Cinema.

Week 33 · Apr 26–May 2 — Senegal

Black Girl (1966, Sembène)

- **Black Girl: Self, Possessed** — Ashley Clark, Criterion. Sembène from Marseille docker to filmmaker; unpacks the mask and the ellipsis in the French title. (*the syllabus's "liner notes"*)
- **Three Revolutionary Films by Ousmane Sembène** — Yasmina Price, Criterion. The film in Sembène's anticolonial project and the griot tradition.
- **Sembène, Ousmane** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors.

Touki Bouki (1973, Mambéty)

- **Touki bouki: Word, Sound, and Power** — Ashley Clark, Criterion. Superb on the soundtrack and Mambéty's "Grandma vs. Grammar."
- **Touki bouki: Mambéty and Modernity** — Richard Porton, Criterion. Complicates the tidy Sembène-realist / Mambéty-modernist split.
- **Anarchic Visions: Djibril Diop Mambéty** — Robert Sklar, *Film Comment* (2000). The fullest free piece on Mambéty.

Xala (1975, Sembène) (*optional*)

- **Three Revolutionary Films by Ousmane Sembène** — Criterion. Reads the impotence curse as a

class diagnosis; strong on Wolof and the Evian gag.

- **Ousmane Sembène: “We are no longer in the era of prophets”** — Michael Atkinson, *Film Comment* (1993).
-

Unit 11 · Germany and the Political Film

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 34 · May 3–9

Aguirre, the Wrath of God (1972, Herzog)

- **Aguirre, the Wrath of God** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On Herzog’s sound, Kinski’s face, and the film as vision rather than plot.
- **Myth, Environment and Ideology in the German Jungle of Aguirre** — Senses of Cinema. Reads the jungle as a German Romantic and colonial construction.
- **Herzog, Werner** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. Places the film in the “ecstatic truth” project.

Ali: Fear Eats the Soul (1974, Fassbinder)

- **Fassbinder’s figures: Jeff Smith on ALI: FEAR EATS THE SOUL** — Jeff Smith, on Bordwell’s blog. Shot-by-shot on the framing and doorway compositions.
- **Ali: Fear Eats the Soul: All That Fassbinder Allows** — Criterion. Fassbinder on Sirk; love as an instrument of social oppression.
- **Todd Haynes on Ali: Fear Eats the Soul** — Criterion. A filmmaker on the Sirk–Fassbinder inheritance.

All That Heaven Allows (1955, Sirk) (*optional*)

- **All That Heaven Allows: An Articulate Screen** — Criterion. On Sirkian irony and the “happy” ending.

Week 35 · May 10–16

The Battle of Algiers (1966, Pontecorvo)

- **The Battle of Algiers: Bombs and Boomerangs** — Jessica Kiang, Criterion. The newsreel style and the refusal of easy sides.
- **The Battle of Algiers Turns Fifty** — Criterion. Fifty years of reception, including the 2003 Pentagon screening. (*the syllabus’s assigned reading*)
- **The Battle of Algiers** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On the documentary illusion.

Z (1969, Costa-Gavras)

- **Z: Sounding the Alarm** — Criterion. The Lambrakis assassination and the birth of the political thriller.
- **Costa-Gavras on Political Filmmaking** — Criterion. The director on using genre for polemic.
- **Z** — Roger Ebert. The 1969 review, useful as a period document.

The Marriage of Maria Braun (1979, Fassbinder) (*optional*)

- **A Market for Emotions: The Marriage of Maria Braun Production History** — Criterion. How the BRD Trilogy fused melodrama with sociology.
- **Fassbinder, Rainer Werner** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors.

Week 36 · May 17–23

Wings of Desire (1987, Wenders)

- **Wings of Desire: Watch the Skies** — Criterion. The film's midpoint status in Wenders's career.
- **On Wings of Desire** — Wim Wenders, Criterion. The director's own 1987 account, from *The Logic of Images*.
- **Wings of Desire** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*.

Night and Fog (1956, Resnais)

- **Night and Fog** — Criterion. Resnais as editor, and the invention of the essay film.
- **Night and Fog: Origins and Controversy** — Criterion. Commissioning, censorship, and the cropped French gendarme.
- **Joshua Oppenheimer on Night and Fog** — Criterion. A documentarian on Resnais's ethical strategies — the right frame before *Come and See*.

Come and See (1985, Klimov)

- **Come and See: Orphans of the Storm** — Criterion. Klimov's sequence-building, and the question of propaganda.
- **Read and See: Ales Adamovich and Literature out of Fire** — Criterion. The Belarusian witness literature behind the script.
- **Come and See** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On the film as an assault rather than a war story.

Shoah (1985, Lanzmann) (*optional*)

- **Approaching Shoah** — Criterion. On Lanzmann's refusal of archival footage — a direct argument with Resnais's method.
- **Shoah at Twenty-Five** — Richard Brody, *The New Yorker*. Reassessment of the method and its critics. (*paywalled*)

Unit 12 · Cinema Now

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 37 · May 24–30

A Separation (2011, Farhadi)

- **Rediscovering Morality Through Asghar Farhadi's A Separation** — Senses of Cinema. On the film's distribution of moral culpability — the "no character is wrong" claim tested.
- **A Separation** — Roger Ebert. "No rules can account for human feelings."

4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days (2007, Mungiu)

- **4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days: Late Term** — Criterion. The long take, Ceaușescu's Romania, and off-screen dread.
- **4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days** — RogerEbert.com. Good on the dinner scene.

The Lives of Others (2006, von Donnersmarck) (*optional; also the Week 36 substitute*)

- **The Stasi on Our Minds** — Timothy Garton Ash, *NYRB*. A historian who read his own Stasi file on what the film gets right and wrong. The best thing written about it. (*paywalled*)
- **The Lives of Others** — RogerEbert.com.

Week 38 · May 31–Jun 6

Memories of Murder (2003, Bong)

- **Memories of Murder: In the Killing Jar** — Criterion. The Hwaseong cold case as a portrait of a police state.
- **10 Things I Learned: Memories of Murder** — Criterion. Production detail on Bong's staging.

Parasite (2019, Bong)

- **PARASITE fever** — Bordwell. On Bong's narrative construction and staging in depth. **The best formal piece on the film.**
- **Parasite: Notes from the Underground** — Criterion. Class architecture and the semi-basement.

Burning (2018, Lee Chang-dong) (*optional*)

- **Burning** — RogerEbert.com. On the film's withheld information and class resentment.
- **Lee Chang-dong** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors.

Week 39 · Jun 7–13

Spirited Away (2001, Miyazaki)

- **Spirited Away** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. On Miyazaki's "pointless" details and non-Western plotting.
- **Miyazaki's Heroines** — Senses of Cinema. Chihiro within Miyazaki's line of girl protagonists.

Portrait of a Lady on Fire (2019, Sciamma)

- **Portrait of a Lady on Fire: Daring to See** — Criterion. Looking, painting, consent.
- **Gazing at the Gaze** — Senses of Cinema. Close reading of the looking structure.
- **How Portrait of a Lady on Fire celebrates the female gaze** — BFI, and the counter-case: “Portrait” Is More Than a “Manifesto on the Female Gaze” — *The New Yorker* (*paywalled*). Read as a pair.

Beau Travail (1999, Denis) (*optional*)

- **Beau travail: A Cinema of Sensation** — Criterion. Melville, masculinity, and Denis’s elliptical construction.
 - **How Bernardo Montet Infused Beau travail with His “Choreographic Thought”** — Criterion. The choreographer on the drills as dance.
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Unit 13 · Capstone — Cinema as Pure Form

← *this unit in the syllabus*

Week 40 · Jun 14–20

2001: A Space Odyssey (1968, Kubrick)

- **2001: A Space Odyssey** — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. The canonical case for the film as experience rather than narrative.
- **“2001”: What It Means, and How It Was Made** — *The New Yorker*. Fiftieth-anniversary production history. (*paywalled*)

Playtime (1967, Tati)

- **Where in the world is M. Hulot?** — Bordwell. On Tati’s shooting plans and camera-movement diagrams — the technical companion to a film built entirely out of staging.
- **Playtime** — Criterion.
- **The Dance of PlayTime** — Criterion. How the film turns looking and listening into choreography.
- **Anxious Metropolis: Alienation in Alphaville and Playtime** — Senses of Cinema. Pairs Tati with Godard on modernist Paris.

La Jetée (1962, Marker)

- **La Jetée: Unchained Melody** — Criterion. How the stills dramatize the breakdown of time.
- **Chris Marker: Memory’s Apostle** — Criterion. Marker’s career and the film as meditation on the medium.
- **Marker, Chris** — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. Broader essay-film context.

Week 41 · Jun 21–27

Mulholland Drive (2001, Lynch)

- [Lim on Lynch: Mulholland Dr.](#) — Dennis Lim, Criterion. The film as botched reenactment and second chance.
- [Mulholland Dr.](#) — Roger Ebert, *Great Movies*. Argues against solving the film.
- [The Perils of Fantasy: Memory and Desire in Mulholland Drive](#) — Senses of Cinema. Sustained reading of the dream structure.

Persona rewatch (1966, Bergman)

- [Persona: 5 films inspired by Ingmar Bergman's masterpiece](#) — BFI. Includes a section drawing the Betty/Rita–Alma/Elisabet parallel directly. The piece for this week.

Week 42 · Jun 28–Jul 4

Jeanne Dielman, 23 quai du Commerce, 1080 Bruxelles (1975, Akerman)

- [A Matter of Time](#) — Criterion. On stasis, duration, and women's work.
 - [Keeping a distance: Chantal Akerman's Jeanne Dielman](#) — *Sight and Sound*. Written around the 2022 poll result; on Akerman's fixed frames.
 - [The Routine Pleasures of Jeanne Dielman](#) — Criterion. Includes Akerman speaking about the domestic rituals.
 - [Akerman, Chantal](#) — Senses of Cinema, Great Directors. The career entry — the right last thing to read.
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Standing sources worth bookmarking

- [The Criterion Current](#) — free essays, searchable by film.
- [David Bordwell, *Observations on Film Art*](#) — plus his [free books page](#), which includes *Planet Hong Kong*, *Ozu and the Poetics of Cinema*, and *Reinventing Hollywood* excerpts.
- [Senses of Cinema](#) — Great Directors index and the CTEQ annotations.
- [RogerEbert.com Great Movies](#)
- [Reverse Shot](#)
- [Film Comment](#)
- [Sight and Sound](#) — partly paywalled.
- [Jonathan Rosenbaum's archive](#) — decades of *Chicago Reader* criticism, free.
- [Scraps from the Loft](#) — reprints of Kael, Sarris, Farber, and other out-of-print criticism.